

Self-Care Traumatic Episode Protocol (STEP)

Manual



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Video Protocol (STEP) by Judy Moench, 2020

STEP was developed in consultation with Elan Shapiro and based on G-TEP

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General Information



Available To Download

This indicates documents that are available to download. The location of the download will be noted.

- STEP SOLO Downloads are available on the website Prepped 4 Learning
- STEP TOGETHER Downloads are available on the Kajabi learning platform
- In the manual, the page will be indicated



Linked

This indicates a link. Click on the underlined text to access.



Something To Remember

This indicates some helpful tips for you to keep in mind.

[] Customizable Information

This indicates that information can be inserted in fillable spaces. For example, adding your logo, name, position, and contact information to forms or emails. These forms can all be found in the sample emails that go with each protocol.

- STEP SOLO on the website Prepped 4 Learning
- STEP TOGETHER on the Kajabi learning platform
- You will have access to all documents.

The Self-Care Traumatic Episode Protocol (STEP)

The Self-Care Traumatic Episode Protocol (STEP) is a low-intensity computerized, guided self-help intervention based on the principles of the Adaptive Information Processing Model and Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing (EMDR) Therapy. EMDR was originally developed by Dr. Francine Shapiro. STEP is adapted from the Group Traumatic Episode Protocol (G-TEP), which was developed by Elan Shapiro following the development of the Recent Traumatic Episode Protocol (R-TEP) with Bruit Laub in 2008.



See more information about EMDR Therapy [here](#).



See more information about G-TEP and a bibliography of the research [here](#).

STEP was developed, in 2020, during the COVID-19 pandemic as a low-intensity intervention that did not require clinicians and clients to meet in person. Rather, this protocol allows clinicians to, within a typical 1.5-hour session, combine psychoeducation and stabilization activities to ensure a present focus, process parts of the ongoing and/or overwhelming event(s) using bilateral stimulation and develop containment strategies. The goal of STEP is to prevent the accumulation of overwhelming memories, decrease distress, and increase coping.



Individual and group versions of STEP have been developed to address varying levels of client distress:

STEP Solo is a clinician-assisted, autonomous protocol designed for individuals experiencing some distress but who do not meet criteria for post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD). A clinician screens participants to ensure they have sufficient self-regulation skills to complete the processing independently. The clinician also monitors participants' scores before and after they complete STEP Solo online to identify when additional support may be needed or if their level of need changes.

STEP Together is used with a clinician-administered group or individually (one-to-one with a clinician). This can be conducted online, in person, or in a hybrid collaborative environment with a combination of in person and virtual participants and/or leaders/facilitators. In a group setting, a group leader, co-leader, and/or facilitator would assist with the delivery of the group and be available to support any members who may require further intervention. When appropriate, STEP Together can be offered individually to ensure adequate support for clients whose needs may not be fully met within a group format.

Supported Steps: STEP Solo and STEP Together are the two main components of the STEP intervention. Brief measures help determine which option is appropriate. If scores indicate it may not be the right time to proceed, the clinician is encouraged to take “Supported Steps”, individualized (one-to-one) actions guided by clinical judgement to determine the most suitable way forward. Supported Steps are not part of the STEP intervention itself, but rather a cue to consider what approach may best support the client at this time.

STEP is not suitable to meet the needs of all clients. Clinical judgement and more comprehensive assessments are necessary to make decisions on the most appropriate intervention for your client, as STEP is designed as a low-intensity intervention for individuals who may benefit from this approach.



Step By Step



STEP Solo (Clinician Assisted; Autonomous User)

STEP Together (Clinician Administered Group or One-to-One)

Supported Steps (Clinician Determined One-to-One Treatment)

STEP Solo and STEP Together are the two core components of the STEP intervention. Prior to using either approach, clients complete brief measures to determine which protocol is suitable. If a client's scores suggest that it may not be the right time to proceed, the clinician is encouraged to take "Supported Steps", our term for the individualized clinical decisions and actions that help determine the most suitable way forward. These Supported Steps are not part of the STEP intervention itself; rather, the term is used to signal the clinician to use their clinical judgement and any additional assessment to identify the approach that will best support the client at this stage.

Ways to Scaffold STEP

STEP is designed to be used with guided support or structured assistance for self-help. The concept of this low-intensity intervention is to provide support at the level that is needed, with the option of gradually reducing the scope of assistance as the client becomes more independent.



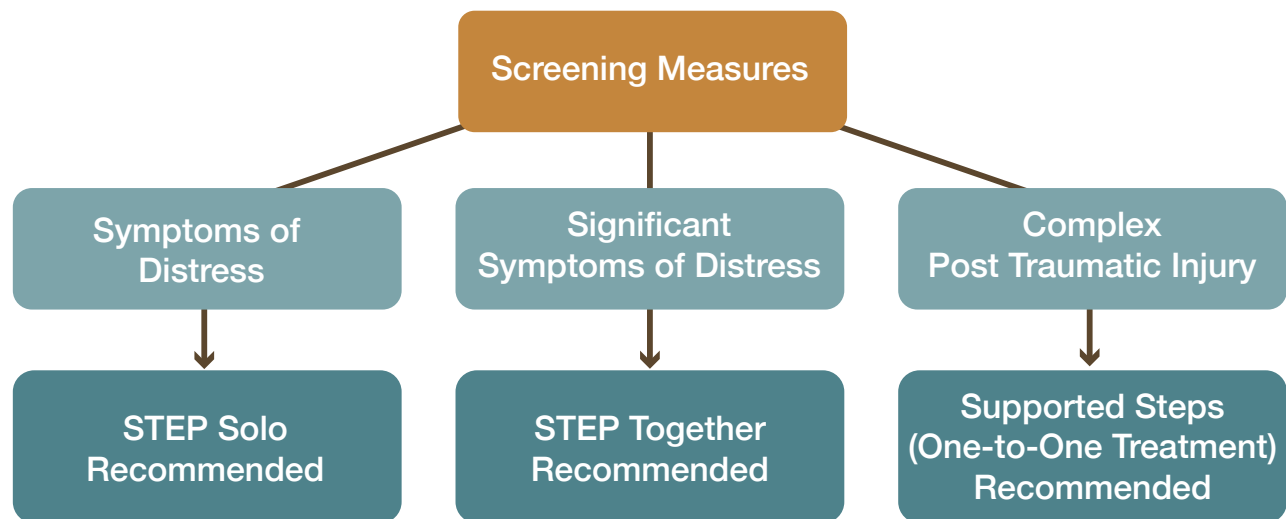
STEP Solo is used autonomously for self-care, to process pieces of a distressing experience or as a tool for maintenance. A clinician monitors computer-scored measures pre-use, during use, and post-use.

STEP Together is used with a clinician-administered group or individually (one-to-one with a clinician). This can be conducted online, in person, or in a hybrid format. In a group setting, a group leader, co-leader, and/or facilitator would assist with the delivery of the group and be available to provide emotional support or engage with any members who may require further intervention.

Supported Steps are recommended with treatments delivered individually by a clinician who actively guides the therapy process and stays with the client for the full duration of the intervention. The clinician is responsible for assessing the client's needs and selecting the most suitable treatment approach.

The STEP Solo and STEP Together interventions are not intended to replace the support of a psychologist, psychiatrist, or other mental health professionals but rather to complement their care by providing a low-intensity computerized intervention for those who may benefit from it.

The STEP Process



We have included a visual guide to the STEP Intervention to help you through the STEP process. We will explore each component in more depth throughout this manual.

Several EMDR protocols have been researched and demonstrated to be effective. Among these, the standard EMDR Therapy protocol developed by Dr. Francine Shapiro is the most extensively studied and evidence-based EMDR Therapy treatment currently available. This protocol should be utilized whenever possible. However, certain circumstances may limit the availability of the standard protocol. In such cases, alternative protocols have been adapted with the aim of offering support to those who may benefit. STEP is one such option, providing a low-intensity, online intervention designed for specific client needs. Please note the guidance on selecting the best protocol for clients on page 13.

The Research

Published Research

STEP was developed during the COVID-19 pandemic to assist Mental Health clinicians, medical staff, and other front-line workers to decrease stress and increase coping. A randomized control study was conducted with EMDR-trained social workers, psychologists, and psychiatrists. The results demonstrated preliminary evidence that STEP significantly reduces depression, anxiety, and stress and increases self-efficacy in the context of COVID-19 compared to waitlist. For more information on this study, please read the abstract below, or read the full article which can be found using the included reference.

The abstract of the study is as follows:

Healthcare workers and Mental Health clinicians are at heightened risk for mental health issues while they support their communities during the COVID-19 pandemic, and early psychological intervention is crucial to protect them. The Self-Care Traumatic Episode Protocol (STEP) is a computerized intervention adapted from the Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing Group Traumatic Episode Protocol (EMDR G-TEP). This study evaluated the effectiveness of STEP for Mental Health clinicians in the context of COVID-19. Thirty-four Mental Health clinicians were randomly allocated to treatment ($n = 17$) or waitlist ($n = 17$). The Generalized Self-Efficacy Scale (GSE) and Depression and Anxiety Stress Scale (DASS- 21) were completed by the treatment group at baseline and 1-week follow-up postintervention and by the waitlist group at baseline, preintervention, and 1-week follow-up post waitlist. Pre–post comparisons showed a significant decrease in depression, anxiety, and stress for Immediate Treatment, $t(15) = -3.64, p < .01, d = .73$, and for Delayed Treatment, $t(15) = -3.53, p < .01, d = .68$. There was also a significant increase in general self-efficacy for Immediate Treatment, $t(15) = 2.87, p < .05, d = .46$, and Delayed Treatment, $t(15) = 3.72, p < .01, d = .56$. The randomized controlled trial (RCT) indicated that STEP may be effective in increasing general self-efficacy and reducing symptoms of depression, anxiety, and stress among Mental Health clinicians in the context of COVID-19. Further research investigating the potential of utilizing the STEP intervention on a larger scale and with other populations is needed.

To read the full study, please go to the Journal of EMDR Practice and Research:



Moench, J. & Billsten, O. (2021). Randomized Controlled Trial: Self-Care Traumatic Episode Protocol, Computerized EMDR Treatment of COVID-19-Related Stress. *Journal of EMDR Practice and Research*, 15(2), 99-113. <http://dx.doi.org/10.1891/EMDR-D-20-00047>

Unpublished Research

A national randomized control study conducted with Canadian EMDR-trained clinicians indicated that STEP significantly reduced symptoms of post-traumatic stress compared to a waitlist. 91.6% of participants indicated that they found STEP helpful, 91.6% would recommend it to a colleague, and 91.3% said it would be a safe and helpful protocol for others to use on a larger scale.

Additional research projects are in development to investigate the effectiveness of STEP with front-line workers including teachers.

Projects

STEP was utilized with an international group working with refugees following a critical incident exposing staff members to significant distress. The group was led by Dr. Judy Moench, from Canada, and facilitated by a registered psychologist in the area of the incident. Participants shared that their Subjective Units of Distress (SUDs) levels decreased. Some shared that they felt more relaxed, others had a positive feeling they did not have prior to the intervention.

At the 2021 EMDR Canada Conference, workshop participants completed the STEP Solo protocol. The participants shared that the 4 Elements video reduced their stress levels, and the STEP Solo protocol reduced the SUDs levels of all participants who completed the full protocol.

A research project conducted with staff members at a mental health clinic working with survivors of sexual violence revealed that STEP Together significantly decreased compassion fatigue, burnout, and subjective units of distress ratings for the target event. The 4 Elements exercise resulted in significant reductions in stress ratings for all participants. STEP Together significantly improved general self-efficacy and resulted in improvements in compassion satisfaction. All participants who completed the feedback form at the end of the intervention indicated that STEP was helpful and they would recommend the intervention to colleagues. Supervisory staff reported that STEP Solo and STEP Together protocols were valuable in supporting their teams and fostering well-being in a supportive workplace environment that allowed staff to maintain their workplace responsibilities. They also highlighted the significantly lower costs of these protocols compared to other treatment options.

What is EMDR?

A Continuum of Therapeutic Supports (Psychotherapy, Procedures, and Techniques)



EMDR PSYCHOTHERAPY

COMPREHENSIVE APPLICATION
OF EMDR THERAPY
Specialized Therapeutic Solutions



The trauma expert will treat the whole person using the three-pronged Adapted Information Processing Model of EMDR Psychotherapy. The full clinical picture will include individual, relational, and behavioral domains in order to optimize the client's capacity to respond adaptively to life challenges resulting from developmental trauma while building/restoring resilience and promoting post traumatic growth. EMDR Psychotherapy incorporates treatment for those presenting psychological disorders and monitors change throughout the eight phases of treatment.

- Comprehensive Treatment Plan
- Therapeutic Alliance
- Collaborative
- Evidence Based

EMDR TREATMENT PROCEDURES

PROTOCOLS FOR
INDIVIDUALS OR GROUPS

Addresses specific disorders, symptoms, special clinical situations



The goal is partial or complete reprocessing of memories that contribute to the client's presenting issues. Procedures can be used as a stand-alone approach or as part of a more comprehensive psychotherapy.

- Considered Innovations (until backed by research if modifications are made to 8 phased, three pronged approach)



EMDR-DERIVED TECHNIQUES

TRUNCATED STRATEGIES UTILIZING CORE ELEMENTS OF
EMDR PSYCHO-THERAPY
May be used as part of clinical assessment



These techniques are either stand-alone brief interventions or a supplement to EMDR Psycho-Therapy. They have one or more goals that may include desensitization of a disturbing memory or part of a memory, reducing distress, increasing stability, improving capacity for emotional self-regulation, preparation for memory reprocessing, as well as strengthen positive experiences.

Used in:

- the field
- clinical sessions
- self-administration by clients



Moench, J. (2022). What is EMDR? [Graphic]. Based on: Laliotis, D., Luber, M., Oren, U., Shapiro, E., Ichii, M., Hase, M., La Rosa, L., Alter-Reid, K., & Tortes St. Jammes, J. (2021). What is EMDR therapy? Past, present, and future directions. *Journal of EMDR Practice and Research*, 15(4), 186–201. <https://doi.org/10.1891/EMDR-D-21-00029>

The STEP Screening Process

The STEP intervention includes several layers of screening to ensure client safety and assist clinicians in determining the most appropriate intervention for their clients.

Determining the Best Protocol for Participants

Low-intensity interventions are an important part of the stepped approach to treatment, as recommended by the UK's National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE, 2022). Stepped care starts with lower-intensity interventions, like STEP Solo, and includes ongoing assessments to determine whether access to more intensive treatments may be helpful, based on the client's needs.

STEP interventions are not recommended for individuals experiencing:

- Suicidal thoughts
- Diagnoses of psychotic or dissociative disorders, including experiences such as hallucinations, delusions, or dissociation
- Complex post-traumatic injuries
 - Use your clinical judgement to determine whether STEP is appropriate, considering circumstances, client needs, and whether additional training, clinician involvement, or facilitator support is needed.

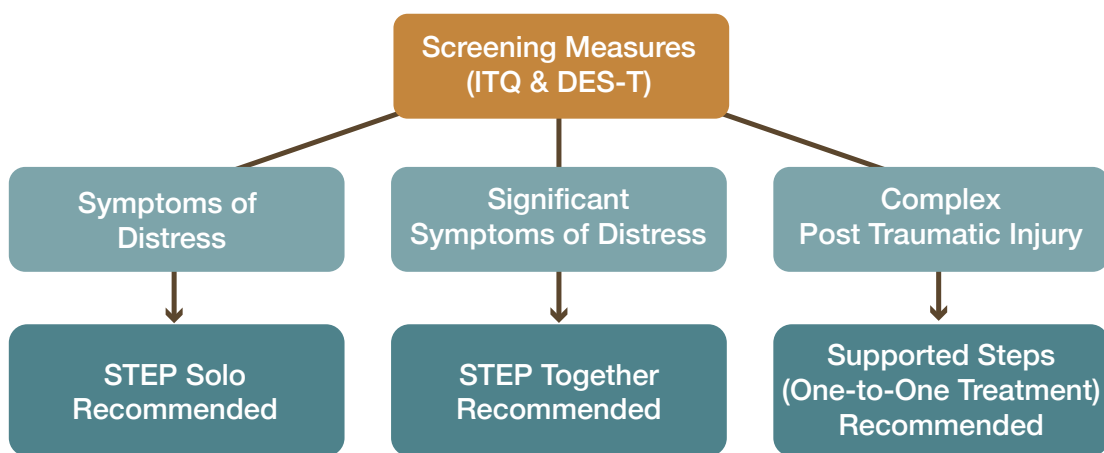
The safety and screening measures integrated into the process are designed to assist STEP Intervention Providers in determining the appropriateness of STEP interventions for their individual clients. Prior to initiating the STEP protocol, providers may utilize free, public domain screening questionnaires, identified in the following pages, to support this decision-making process. These preliminary tools are not part of the STEP protocol and do not constitute the beginning of a STEP intervention. Clinicians should integrate their knowledge of the client's history, needs, and circumstances, and apply clinical judgement, consultation, and ethical decision-making models when determining whether to proceed. STEP begins only when the intervention protocol is implemented; the use of public domain questionnaires is separate and preparatory in nature. Clinicians may use measures such as the ITQ or DES-T, or integrate other organization-required tools or those typically used in their practice, provided they are valid and reliable assessments of complex PTSD, dissociation, or related mental-health factors relevant to participant safety.

First Screening

Clients will first complete the International Trauma Questionnaire (ITQ; Cloitre et al., 2018) and the Dissociative Experiences Scale Taxon (DES-T; Carlson et al., 1991) to determine if STEP is an appropriate intervention for them. The results, paired with clinical judgement, will guide clinicians in allocating clients to the STEP Solo or STEP Together, Supported Steps or other available treatment options.

The **ITQ** is a brief measure consisting of 18 questions that assess the core features of post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) and complex post-traumatic stress disorder (CPTSD).

The **DES-T** is an eight-question screening measure used to assess the level of dissociation being experienced by the client.



The client's scores are sent to the clinician. If they are experiencing significant symptoms of distress (e.g., probable PTSD), STEP Together is recommended. If they have a complex post-traumatic injury (e.g., probable Complex PTSD), it is recommended that Supported Steps be taken with the client and an appropriate evidence-based treatment with clinician-supported one-to-one intervention should be utilized.

Prior to determining if STEP may be suitable, and if so, which protocol may be best, the measures are scored by the computer and sent to the clinician. If the client is experiencing distress, but does not have symptoms indicative of PTSD, STEP Solo may be best. If the client is experiencing significant symptoms of distress (e.g., probable PTSD), STEP Together or Supported Steps (one-to-one treatment) is recommended. If the client is experiencing a complex post-traumatic injury (e.g., probable complex PTSD), it is recommended that Supported Steps are offered to the client with an appropriate evidence-based treatment and clinician involvement. The STEP Intervention Provider may choose to use STEP interventions for this population if deemed appropriate through further investigation, clinical judgement, and assessment.

Clients who are experiencing the following may benefit from the higher levels of support offered by STEP Together:

- Diagnostic scoring on the ITQ suggests that the client may meet the criteria for post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), but not complex post-traumatic stress disorder (CPTSD).
- DES-T scores are below 20, which generally indicate dissociative experiences within an expected range and do not suggest a need for additional dissociation-focused support.

Clients who are experiencing the following may benefit from the higher levels of individual support offered by Supported Steps (one-to-one treatment):

- Diagnostic scoring on the ITQ suggests that the client may meet the criteria for complex post-traumatic stress disorder (CPTSD).
- A DES-T score above 20 typically indicates an elevated level of dissociative experiences, which may signal that the person could benefit from higher levels of support. When scores on the DES-T rise above 35, responses are more consistent with clinically significant (or “pathological”) dissociation. In this case, Supportive Steps might include a more comprehensive assessment can help clarify which therapeutic approach or intervention protocol may be most appropriate to meet the person’s needs.

The questions on the DES-T look at a variety of dissociative experiences, including some that are common and typical. **A score of zero on the DES-T may need further follow-up or discussion as it may reflect underreporting, limited awareness of dissociative experiences, or misunderstanding of the questions.**

These score ranges that suggest a need for additional support were derived from those suggested by the creators of the measures and those suggested in the research (Carlson et al., 1991, Cloitre et al., 2018, Fung et al., 2020, Ross et al., 2002; Waller & Ross, 1997) to indicate clinically significant levels of symptoms and severe needs. Clinical judgement should be used when selecting the most appropriate intervention for a client.



Second Screening

Following this initial screening, the clients will complete an additional round of measures. This serves as an additional safety and screening measure for **STEP Solo participants**, as suggested score ranges that suggest a need for additional support are included to determine if **STEP Solo** is an appropriate intervention for the client. Additionally, for **STEP Together** and **Supported Steps**, these measures provide pre-and-post data to monitor the effectiveness of the intervention and guide treatment planning.

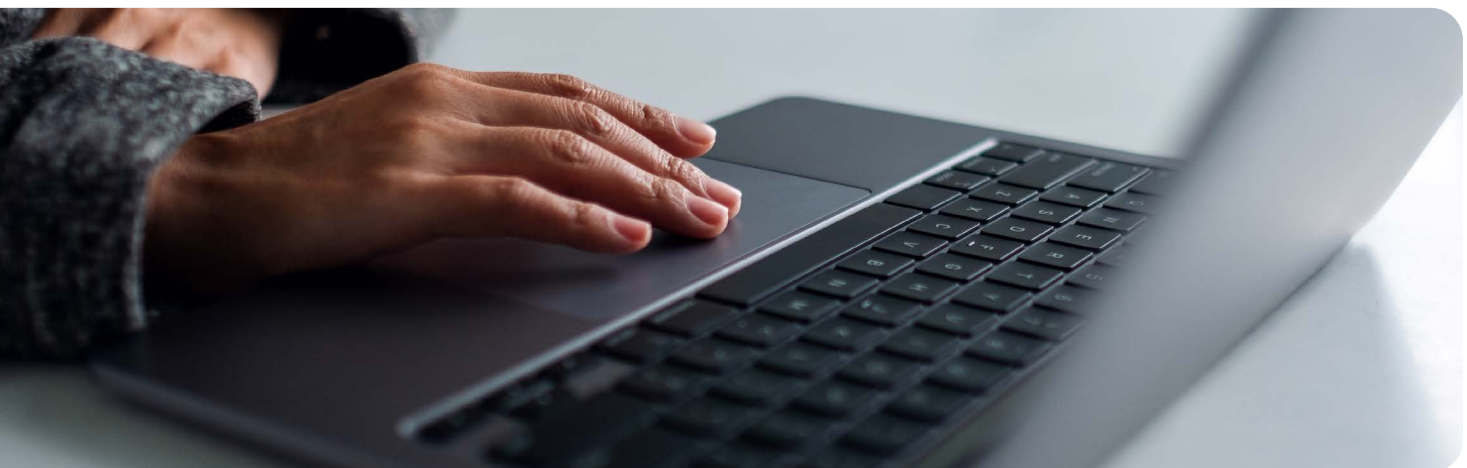
Clients complete the PTSD Checklist for DSM-5 (PCL-5; Weathers et al., 2013), the Depression, Anxiety, Stress Scale (DASS-21; Lovibond & Lovibond, 1995) and the Generalized Self-Efficacy Scale (GSE; Schwarzer & Jerusalem, 1995):

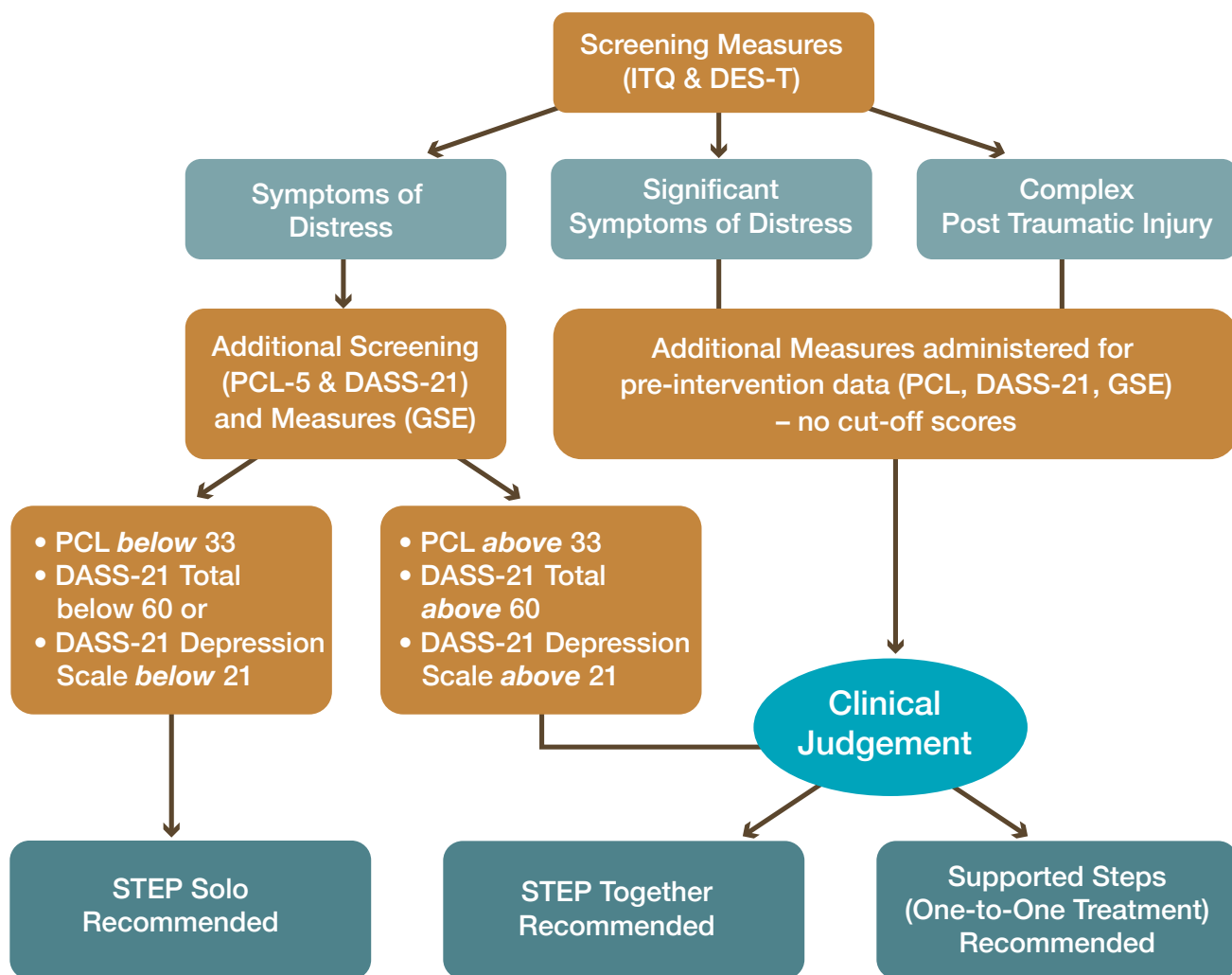
The **PCL-5** is a 20-item assessment developed by the US Department of Veteran's Affairs that measures the DSM-V symptoms of PTSD.

The **DASS-21** is a widely used 21-item assessment that measures symptoms of depression, anxiety, and stress, including dysphoria and devaluation of life, situational anxiety, autonomic arousal, difficulty relaxing and irritability.

The **GSE** is a 10-item assessment of perceived self-efficacy. Perceived self-efficacy relates to our ability to set goals, our views of our own capabilities, and the belief that we can cope and recover from adverse events.

Client scores on these measures assist the clinician in determining which protocol may be most beneficial for the client. However, these are recommendations and do not override the clinical judgement and guidance provided by more in-depth assessments by licensed mental health professionals. See page 24 for suggestions for complimenting the STEP process with personalized guidance.





In **STEP Solo**, participants whose scores indicate high levels of post-traumatic stress are advised to engage in interventions that provide greater support, such as STEP Together or an another appropriate intervention decided through Supportive Steps. Their scores are shared with their clinician, and allocation to a STEP Together group or one-to-one intervention is determined based on the client’s needs, clinical judgement, and further assessment.

The following scores indicate clients may benefit from the higher levels of support offered by STEP Together or One-to-One Interventions:

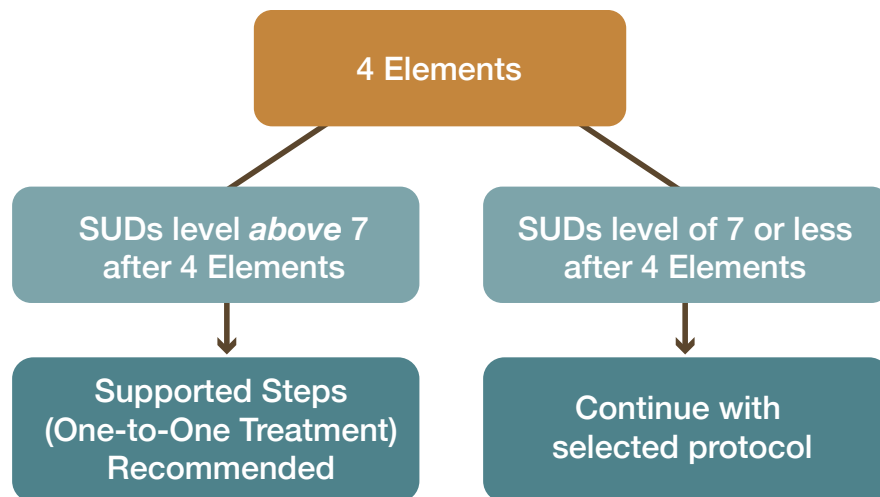
- **Above 33 on the PCL-5** (clinically significant symptoms of PTSD)
- **An overall score of above 60** (severe distress) **or a Depression scale score above 21** (severe depression) **on the DASS-21**

These score ranges that suggest a need for additional support were derived from those suggested by the creators of the PCL-5 (Weathers et al., 2015) and DASS-21 (Lovibond & Lovibond, 1995) to indicate clinically significant levels of symptoms and severe needs.

In **STEP Together**, the clients will complete the PCL-5, DASS-21, and GSE. Scores will still be emailed to the clinician. There are no score ranges that suggest a need for additional support for these measures in STEP Together. Instead, client suitability is determined by the initial ITQ and DES-T screening and clinical judgement of a licensed mental health professional.

Third Screening

A third safety and screening mechanism is present within the intervention itself. If the client is unable to decrease their Subjective Units of Distress Score (SUDs) to 7 or below (on a scale where 0 is low and 10 is high) using the **4 Elements Exercise**, it indicates that the client may be having difficulty self-regulating and calming their body and mind and may benefit from a more intensive individual intervention (Supported Steps).



Administering the STEP Intervention Screening Measures

Overview of Screening Measures

The Screening Measures are administered online through Formstack, a secure survey platform designed to protect sensitive information. Formstack encrypts all data during transmission and storage, ensuring the safety of your client's information.

These tools are free, public domain screening measures that are not part of the STEP intervention itself. They should be used in conjunction with clinical judgement, ethical decision-making, and an understanding of the client's unique history and needs to determine which protocol will be most appropriate for the client.

Commitment to Privacy

At Prepped 4 Learning Inc., we prioritize safeguarding the information entrusted to us. We comply with Alberta's Personal Information Protection Act (PIPA) and other relevant privacy laws, managing data responsibly and ethically. Our data collection is limited to what is necessary to deliver services effectively while maintaining strict client confidentiality.

To ensure privacy, clinicians must assign each client an anonymized, unique identifier. This identifier replaces the client's name on all forms, preserving confidentiality while allowing responses to be matched with the correct client. Prepped 4 Learning Inc. will not have access to information linking the unique identifier to a client's identity.

In line with our commitment to privacy, we carefully select platforms such as Formstack, Kajabi, and Squarespace to support our operations. Formstack's secure data collection and encryption tools align with our need for confidentiality, while Kajabi's robust data protection features ensure compliance when managing online courses or client interactions. Similarly, Squarespace Courses provides a secure and user-friendly environment for delivering educational content and maintaining high standards of data privacy and protection. All three platforms enable us to deliver services effectively without compromising the privacy of client information.

The Prepped 4 Learning Inc. Personal Information Protection Policy is available upon request. Please email your request to prepped4learning@gmail.com.

Creating Unique Identifiers

Clinicians can create unique identifiers using methods that align with their workflow. Consider the following best practices:

- **Secure Storage:** Maintain a secure record of each client's unique identifier alongside their identity in a safe location, such as a password-protected file. This ensures you can match responses to clients while preserving privacy.
- **Distinct Identifiers:** Ensure each identifier is unique and not reused for multiple clients.
- **Avoid Personal Details:** Do not use names, email addresses, or any identifiers easily linked to the client's identity.

Examples of Unique Identifiers:

- A random alphanumeric string, e.g., "7fG8Hk9J"
- A sequential numbering system specific to your practice, e.g., "Client001," "Client002"

To protect client confidentiality, unique identifiers should be accessible to the clinician only, and not to any member of the organization who may be assisting with group scheduling or organization.

Informing Clients

Inform your clients about the following:

- **Privacy Precautions:** While robust measures are in place to protect their information, digital systems carry inherent risks, such as unauthorized access or technical errors.
- **Acknowledgment of Risks:** By proceeding, clients acknowledge these risks and agree that your organization and Prepped 4 Learning Inc. are not liable for unintended disclosures or technical issues beyond our control.
- **Questions and Concerns:** Encourage clients to raise any questions or concerns before completing the forms.
- **Research:** The anonymous data they submit may be used for research purposes. If they would like to opt out of any research, the STEP Intervention Provider should contact prepped4learning@gmail.com to submit a request with the clients unique identifier to have their data excluded from any analyses.

A sample information letter and consent form are included in this manual, and are intended to be used as a guide. These documents are available to download, edit, and use. See page 25 and 26.

Administering the Forms

Clients will complete the measures by accessing links provided by their STEP Intervention Provider. The process includes:

1. Links to Screening Measures: Provide clients with the appropriate links:

-  [Initial Screening](#) (ITQ & DES-T)
-  [Pre-and-Post-Test Data](#) (PCL-5, DASS-21, & GSE):

2. Client Instructions: When opening the form, clients will be asked for:

- Their unique identifier
- The name of their STEP Intervention Provider

3. Submission and Results: Upon submission, the scores will be automatically emailed to the STEP Intervention Provider from Formstack.

Metadata Collection

Formstack may collect limited metadata, such as the date and time of submission. This metadata is used solely for operational purposes to improve service functionality. It is not linked to client identities or used beyond what is necessary to support service delivery.

For further details, refer to their  [Privacy Policy](#).



Important Notes

- **Screening Purpose:** The screening measures are intended to inform treatment planning only. They should not be used for diagnostic or formal assessment purposes. Clinical judgement should be used when interpreting the results.
- **Identifier Confidentiality:** The unique identifier system is critical to maintaining client confidentiality. Clinicians must ensure identifiers are unique and securely stored to prevent confusion or breaches.

By following these guidelines, you can confidently administer the Screening Measures while ensuring your clients' privacy and security.

IMPORTANT: Please ensure you have received obtained consent and scores from screening measures prior to beginning. Provide your clients with access to the login information for STEP Solo after you have obtained informed consent and received and reviewed all of the screening measures.



A Human Connection: Enhancing Support

Integrating an additional human connection into an online protocol may enhance its effectiveness, creating a more engaging and supportive experience. This blend of technology and human interaction fosters trust, encourages meaningful engagement, and personalizes the intervention. By combining this innovative EMDR intervention technique with genuine connection, the protocol becomes not just a method of delivering care but a dynamic and enriching part of the healing process.

This intervention has been successfully implemented with service providers facing the risk of burnout due to the demanding nature of their work. Supervisors found that incorporating “human check-ins” with staff not only added an added level of care but also fostered a more supportive workplace environment.

By offering accessible and cost-effective mental health support, these check-ins, in addition to the online intervention, have helped clients feel valued, supported, and better equipped to manage their well-being.

Having an in-house STEP Intervention Provider can be a great resource for staff, offering a trusted point of contact to help them navigate the best options for mental health support. If this approach is taken, it’s important that the person in this role isn’t in a supervisory position and maintains strong confidentiality boundaries. This ensures that staff feel comfortable opening up and seeking help in a safe and judgement-free environment.

Another option is to bring in a trained STEP Intervention Provider from outside the organization which offers extra guidance and an added element of care while also giving staff a deeper level of reassurance of confidentiality. This approach creates a comfortable space for employees to seek support without feeling too close to in-house human resource personnel, helping them feel heard and valued in a way that respects their privacy.

Complimenting the STEP Process with Personalized Guidance

Incorporating a “**human handoff**”—a check-in where clients receive guidance and resource recommendations—can be a valuable addition for those who are screened toward Supported Steps (alternative treatments that may be more appropriate for their needs).

Sometimes, participants may be redirected toward alternative treatments but still feel that the STEP intervention would benefit them. In these cases, it’s important for the STEP Intervention Provider to discuss available options and use clinical judgement and/or seek consultation to determine the most suitable approach. Depending on individual circumstances, the provider and participant may decide to proceed with the STEP intervention or explore other pathways. Having a knowledgeable STEP Intervention Provider available ensures thoughtful decision-making and tailored support.

To further enhance accessibility and comfort, agencies may consider having multiple STEP Intervention Providers, allowing staff to choose the provider with whom they feel most comfortable working. This also provides a way for staff to address any concerns about their protocol access, intervention plans, and ongoing progress.

Additionally, offering the STEP intervention as a **maintenance tool**—whether on an as-needed basis or at regular intervals—can serve as a proactive approach to supporting employee well-being and preventing burnout.

The emails included in this protocol serve as examples of how the protocol developers have integrated the human component into the STEP Protocol. STEP Intervention Providers are encouraged to personalize these emails, ensuring they reflect their own voice, values, and treatment goals. These templates are intended as guides to support service provision and can be modified as needed to best meet the needs of both the provider and the participant seeking services. For example, you may need to adapt the language in the emails and forms to be appropriate for the demographic of your clients, or include additional technical support or guidance for participants.

Before You Begin

Information Letter for Participants

Informed consent is critical to maintaining trust, transparency, and professionalism. It ensures clients fully understand and agree to the purpose, benefits, and potential risks of the STEP intervention, fostering a strong foundation of mutual respect and accountability.

Beyond being an ethical and legal obligation, informed consent protects both clients and practitioners by clarifying expectations and reducing misunderstandings. It empowers clients to make informed decisions, promotes shared responsibility, and enhances their commitment to the process.

Please ensure you are obtaining full and informed consent from your clients before using the STEP intervention. This includes informed consent about telepsychology and the use of technology.

If you are located in Alberta and governed by the College of Alberta Psychologists, practice guidelines are available regarding Informed Consent and Use of Technology: <https://www.cap.ab.ca/resources-regulatory-information/practice-guidelines>. If you are not from Alberta, please refer to the guidelines of your professional discipline and/or your field of expertise or specialization.

To ensure full and informed consent, we recommend providing your clients with:

- an information letter about the process
- a consent and terms of use form



Sample Information Letter for Participants

For STEP Solo: Download the Sample Information Letter for Participants [here](#) (Password: STEP-resources).

For STEP Together: Download the Sample Information Letter for Participants from Kajabi (see module “Before the Group”).

Consent and Terms of Use

In addition to the standard informed consent requirements of your profession, it's important to incorporate **program-specific terms of use**. These terms outline the specific guidelines, expectations, and responsibilities related to the STEP intervention.

The clinicians implementing the STEP interventions maintain full responsibility for addressing the mental health needs of their clients and those they give access to the protocol(s). *Prepped 4 Learning Inc. is not liable for client outcomes or clinical decisions made by those using the protocols. Use of the videos does not constitute a therapist-client relationship with participants for Prepped 4 Learning Inc.*

Program-specific terms of use clarify details such as participation rules, privacy policies, data handling, and any unique risks associated with the program. By including these terms, you ensure that clients are fully informed about all aspects of the program beyond general consent, protecting both the client and the program provider. This ensures transparency, minimizes potential misunderstandings, and reinforces the commitment to a safe and effective experience for everyone involved.

As the provider of the STEP intervention, you are responsible for communicating the terms of use to your clients.



Sample Consent Form and Terms of Use

For STEP Solo: Download the Sample Consent and Terms of Use document [here](#) (Password: STEP-resources).

For STEP Together: Download the Sample Consent and Terms of Use document on Kajabi (see module “Before the Group”).

Keeping Track of Participant Information

When conducting mental health services online, it's essential to have a process in place to address potential technological disruptions and/or client distress.

Collecting the following information in advance ensures you can respond quickly and appropriately in these situations:

- STEP Intervention Participant Name
- Phone Number Available During Interventions
- Email Address
- Emergency Contact
- Physical location during the STEP intervention
- Nearest Mental Health Clinic or Hospital

It's also helpful to include a statement that STEP Intervention Participants should update their contact details if anything changes during the course of your Interventions.

For security, be sure to store this information in compliance with privacy laws and make sure only authorized individuals can access it.

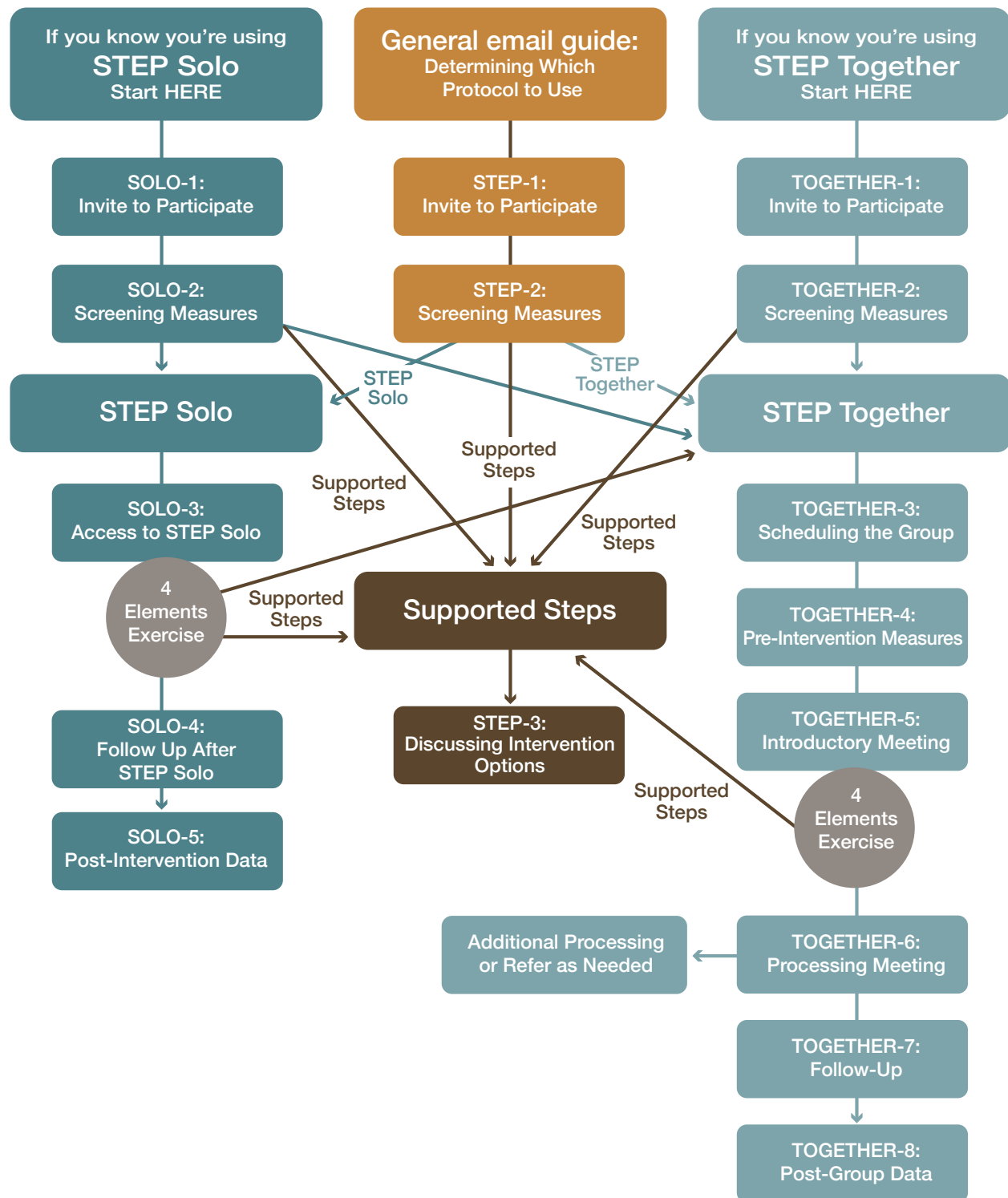
In this manual, we have included a form for keeping track of this information for your STEP Together group participants.



Sample STEP Participants Contact Information Form

This form is available to download and use. See module “Before the Group” on Kajabi.

Sequence of Sample Emails for the STEP Intervention



Inviting Participants to the STEP Intervention

If you want to utilize the STEP intervention with participants but are uncertain whether they will be referred to STEP Solo, STEP Together, or Supported Steps to determine an appropriate one-to-one intervention, you can use the following sequence of emails to explain and start the STEP process. The STEP intervention is designed to collect important information that will assist in developing an effective treatment plan guided by data and clinical judgement, and tailored to their needs.



If you know you want to use **STEP Solo** with participants, proceed with the email sequence outlined in the sample email sequence on the Prepped 4 Learning website.



If you know you want to use **STEP Together** with participants, proceed with the email sequence outlined in the sample email sequence on Kajabi.

List of General Emails to Determine Which Protocol to Use (STEP Solo, STEP Together, or Alternative Interventions)

- STEP-1: Invite to Participate (with Consent and Information)
- STEP-2: Screening Measures
- STEP-3: Discussing Intervention Options
 - *or* SOLO-3: Access to STEP Solo
 - *or* TOGETHER-3: Scheduling the Group



STEP-1: Invite to Participate (with Consent and Information)

For STEP Solo: Download the sample emails [here](#) (Password: STEP-resources).

For STEP Together: Download the sample emails on Kajabi (see module “Before the Group”).

Subject: Invitation to Participate in STEP



Two Attachments: Consent & Terms of Use for STEP Interventions and Information Letter for STEP Interventions (see pages 25 and 26)

Hello **[Insert Participant Name]**,

We would like to invite you to participate in the STEP intervention, which combines psychoeducation, stabilization techniques, processing, and containment strategies. The intervention aims to help you stay grounded, process overwhelming experiences or ongoing events, and continue functioning effectively in your daily life.

Please find attached two important documents:

- **Information Letter:** This outlines the intervention approach, including the protocol, safety considerations, and details on data collection.
- **Consent Form:** This explains what participation involves and confirms agreement to take part.

What to Expect:

- **Consent Form:** Please read and complete the attached consent form. It includes important details on:
 - Confidentiality and privacy guidelines
 - Your rights and responsibilities as a participant
- **Pre-Meeting Forms:** After we receive your consent form, you will be asked to complete some online forms and measures to track your progress and assess your readiness for the intervention. Your data will be collected online and shared with **[insert STEP Intervention Provider name]** to help monitor your participation. Your information will be kept confidential. The data may be used for protocol improvements, research, or teaching, and all personal information will be kept anonymous.

- **Screening and Evaluation:** After we receive your consent form, we will ask you to complete some online forms and measures to track your progress and assess which version of STEP may be a good fit for you.
- **Screening Review:** After we receive all completed screening documents from you, we will review the information to determine the best intervention for you. We will notify you to discuss the next steps in your care. If another type of intervention may be more beneficial, we will discuss alternatives.
- **Accessing the Intervention:** If STEP is selected as an intervention that may be helpful, we will send you information about how we will proceed with the intervention.
- **Follow-Up:** Shortly after completing STEP, we will check in to see how the process went and discuss the next steps. Additionally, we will send you some post-intervention measures to evaluate the effectiveness of the intervention and to get your feedback on the protocol.

To participate, please read and complete the attached consent form. Once we receive your signed consent, we will follow up with the screening measures. If you have any questions or need further clarification, please feel free to contact us; we will be happy to assist you.

Kind regards,

[Insert Your Name]

[Insert Your Role]

[Insert Organization Name]

STEP-2: Screening Measures

For STEP Solo: Download the sample emails [here](#) (Password: STEP-resources).

For STEP Together: Download the sample emails on Kajabi (see module “Before the Group”).

Note: Sending the screening measures (ITQ and DES-T) and the pre-and post-data forms (PCL-5, DASS-21, and GSE) at the same time can be overwhelming for some participants. Use your clinical judgement and knowledge of your clients to determine if the measures should be sent in two emails - the first with the screening measures, and the second with the pre-and post-data forms if the screening measures suggest they can proceed with STEP Solo or STEP Together.



When to Send: Send this email when you receive the signed consent form.

Subject: STEP: Measures to Complete and Unique ID

Hello **[Insert Participant Name]**,

Thank you for taking the time to complete the consent form.

To continue, we’ve attached some pre-screening measures for you to complete. These measures are designed to determine the intervention that will be most appropriate for you. Your data will be collected online and shared with us via email.

When completing the measures, **please use the unique identifier provided below instead of your name**. This ensures confidentiality and helps us securely match your responses to your record:

- **Your Unique Identifier:** **[Insert Unique ID]**

You will also be asked for your STEP Intervention Provider’s name. This ensures the data is sent to the correct provider. Your provider is:

- **STEP Intervention Provider:** **[Insert Name]**

Please rest assured that your data will be handled with the utmost care. Only your unique identifier and scores will be sent to the STEP Intervention Provider via email. This approach maintains your privacy and ensures that your personal information remains protected.

Please complete the following screening measures:

- Initial Screening
- Pre-and-Post-Test Data

Please complete these screening measures before [insert date].

If you have any questions or encounter any issues while completing the measures, please don't hesitate to reach out. You can reply to this email or call us at [insert contact number].

Kind regards,

[Insert Your Name]

[Insert Your Role]

[Insert Organization Name]



After you receive the screening and pre-intervention data from email STEP-2, use the results to determine whether clients will continue with STEP Solo, STEP Together, or Supported Steps (one-to-one treatment).

Based on these results, you will send one of the following emails:

- Proceeding with STEP Solo: email **SOLO-3 – Access to STEP Solo** (sample available on the Prepped 4 Learning website) and then continue with the STEP Solo email sequence.
- Proceeding with STEP Together: email **TOGETHER-3 – Scheduling the Group** (sample available on Kajabi) and then continue with the STEP Together email sequence.
- Proceeding with one-to-one intervention: email **STEP-3 – Discussing Intervention Options** (see below).



STEP-3: Discussing Intervention Options

For STEP Solo: Download the sample emails [here](#) (Password: STEP-resources).

For STEP Together: Download the sample emails on Kajabi (see module “Before the Group”).



Please note: *This email is only for individuals who will not be proceeding with STEP Solo or STEP Together because scores or your clinical judgement have determined it is not an appropriate intervention at this time.*

As a part of Supported Steps, you may select to use the STEP Together protocol in a one-to-one format if appropriate. If STEP is not an appropriate intervention for your client, please discuss alternative interventions that may be better suited to their needs.



When to Send: When you send this email will depend on your timeline; however, we recommend responding as soon as possible after you receive the screening results.

Subject: STEP: Next Steps

Hello **[Insert Participant Name]**,

Thank you for completing the screening measures. Based on the results, we'd like to discuss some interventions that may suit your needs. We would like to book a time to meet **[in person/on the phone/virtually]**. I am available **[Insert date and time options or your online booking system link]**; please let me know what works for you.

Looking forward to connecting soon.

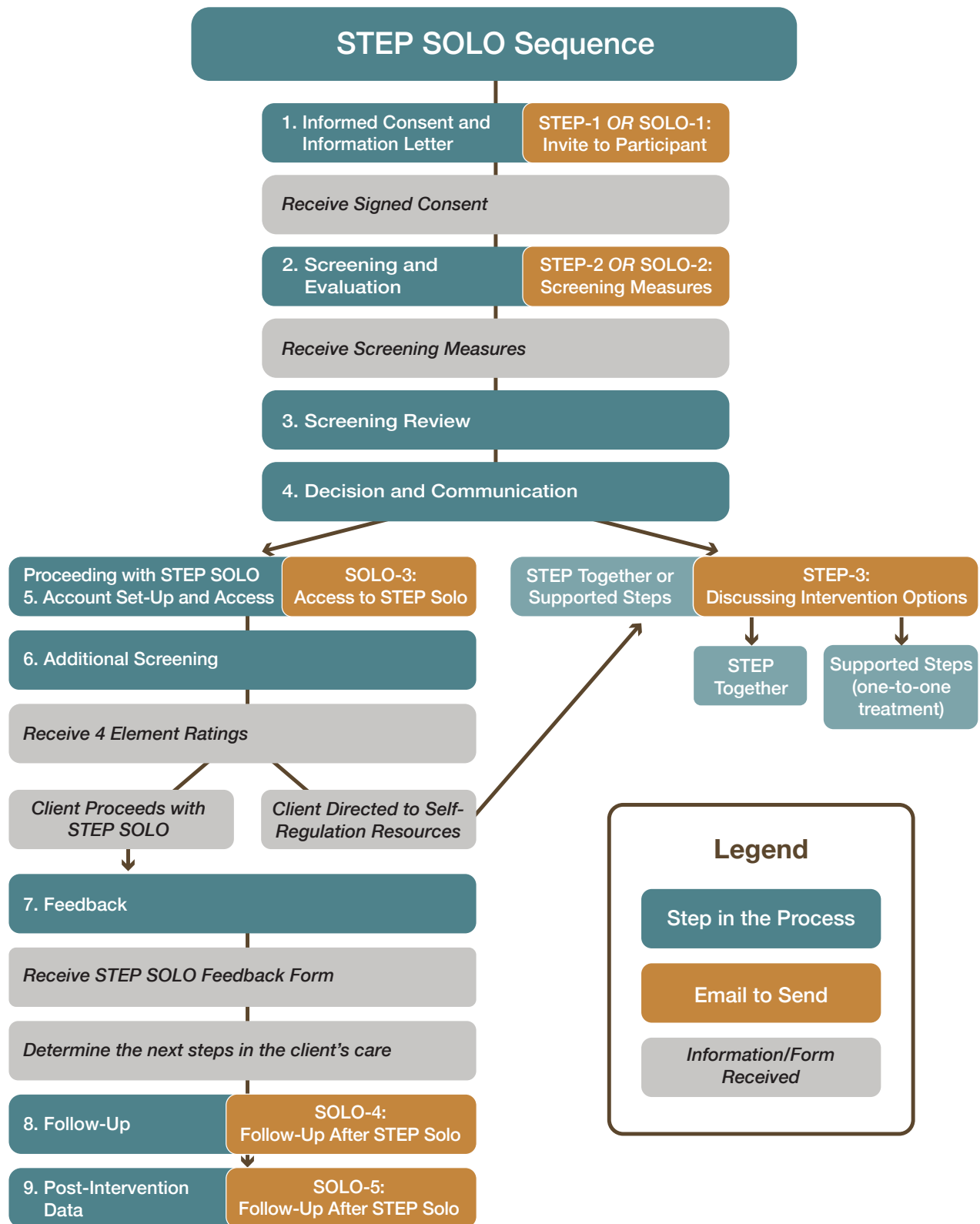
Best regards,

[Insert Your Name]

[Insert Your Position]

[Insert Your Contact Information]

Providing the STEP Solo Intervention



1. Consent and Information Letter: Review informed consent and terms of use and the information letter with your client after determining they may benefit from STEP.

-  See page 25 for a sample informed consent
-  See page 26 for a sample information letter

2. Screening and Evaluation: Once a client expresses interest in the STEP Solo intervention, ask them to complete the screening measures (ITQ & DES-T) and the pre-and post-data forms (PCL-5, DASS-21, GSE). These measures are essential for determining if STEP Solo is the right fit for their needs.

-  [Initial Screening](#)
-  [Pre-and-Post-Test Data](#)

3. Screening Review: After receiving all completed screening documents from the client, review the information to determine if STEP Solo is an appropriate intervention for them.

- See Page 13-22 of the manual for screening information.

4. Decision and Communication: Once you have determined that STEP Solo is suitable, notify the STEP Intervention Participant to discuss options. Please ensure the STEP Intervention Participant receives a list of resources (e.g., Crisis lines, emergency services, community or specialty hotlines) they can use in the event alternative interventions have been selected to better meet their needs.

-  See the Prepped 4 Learning website for the STEP Solo Sample Email document (email **STEP-3: Discussing Intervention Options or SOLO-3: Access to STEP Solo**). Depending on the client's needs, they may complete STEP Together or you might consider Supported Steps - selecting another intervention that might be more appropriate for their needs. If the STEP Intervention Participant will be completing STEP Together, proceed to the STEP Together process on page 40.

5. Account Setup and Access: If STEP Solo is deemed appropriate, provide the client with the login information to access the platform.

-  Download email SOLO-3: Access to STEP Solo in the Sample Email document on the [Prepped 4 Learning website](#) (Password: STEP-resources).
-  [Access STEP Solo](#)

6. Additional Screening: In the STEP Solo Portal, the STEP Intervention Participants will submit their Subjective Units of Distress (SUD) score after the 4 Elements exercise. If their distress remains above seven on the 0-10 scale, they will be asked to contact their STEP Intervention Provider to discuss alternative interventions. You will receive an email with their results. Please ensure that you follow up with any STEP Intervention Participants whose needs may require alternative interventions in a timely manner to adapt their treatment plan with a more suitable intervention.

-  Download email STEP-3: Discussing Intervention Options in the Sample Email document on the [Prepped 4 Learning website](#) (Password: STEP-resources).

7. Feedback: Once they have completed the protocol, they will submit their feedback forms in the STEP Solo portal. Once you receive their feedback forms via email, please review the results to determine if they would benefit from additional processing or another intervention and follow up accordingly.

8. Follow-Up: Shortly after your STEP Intervention Participant completes STEP Solo, check in with them to see how the process went and discuss the next steps.

-  Download email SOLO-4: Follow Up After STEP Solo in the Sample Email document on the [Prepped 4 Learning website](#) (Password: STEP-resources).

9. Post-Intervention Data: One week after they complete STEP Solo, please send the pre- and post-data forms (PCL-5, DASS-21, and GSE) to evaluate the effectiveness of the intervention. Use this data to inform your treatment plan.

-  Download email SOLO-5: Post-Intervention Data in the Sample Email document on the [Prepped 4 Learning website](#) (Password: STEP-resources).

Timeline: The STEP Intervention Provider determines the timeline. We suggest sending login details within **one week** of the decision to proceed with the intervention.

STEP Intervention Participants will be guided through the protocol via a series of videos and screening exercises. These exercises will help determine if this protocol is suitable for them at this time. If alternative interventions are indicated, they will receive suggestions and be encouraged to connect with their mental health provider for further guidance. This ensures a personalized and supportive experience throughout the process.

Emails for STEP Solo

List of Emails

- SOLO-1: Invite to Participate (with Consent and Information)
- SOLO-2: Screening Measures
- SOLO-3: Access to STEP Solo
- SOLO-4: Follow-Up After Completing STEP Solo
- SOLO-5: Post-Intervention Data
- SOLO-6: Sending Pre-Intervention Measures Again
- SOLO-7: Password Change



Downloadable samples of these emails are available on the [Prepped 4 Learning website](#) (Password: STEP-resources)



If your client has been directed to self-regulation resources after the 4 Elements exercise rather than the processing portion of the protocol, send the email below:



STEP-3: Discussing Intervention Options (See page 34 in the manual) to discuss intervention options that may better meet their needs.



Removing Access to STEP Solo

Clients access STEP Solo using a shared login. All clients will utilize the same username and password. If you need to remove access for a specific client, please update the shared login credentials (username and/or password) via the website. Once the credentials are updated, promptly notify the remaining clients who still require access to the protocol about the new login details.

For enhanced security, we recommend regularly updating the shared login information to ensure that former clients no longer have access to the protocol.



After changing the password, to notify clients who will still have access to the updated log-in credentials, send email:



Download email SOLO-7: Password Change in the Sample Email document on the [Prepped 4 Learning website](#) (Password: STEP-resources).

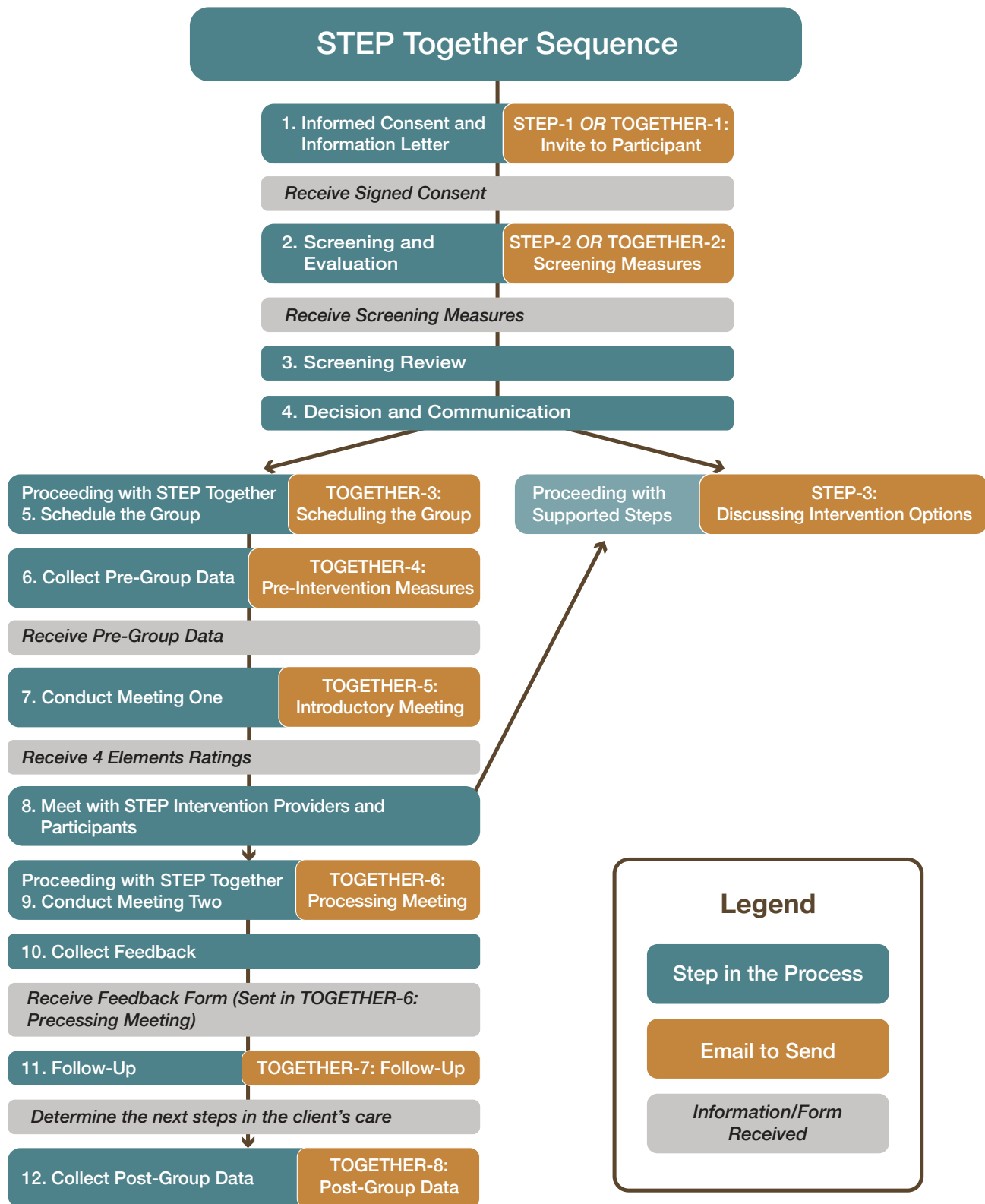
STEP Solo Platform

STEP Solo is hosted on Squarespace Courses, offering an intuitive and user-friendly platform designed to support users through the processing journey. Upon logging in, users are greeted by a dashboard with an introductory message, an overview of the modules, and progress tracking, allowing for easy navigation.

The protocol is organized into modules, guiding users step-by-step through the process. Each module includes a combination of videos, written content, and downloadable resources to ensure a comprehensive and balanced approach. The platform's design features clear menus and a responsive layout, ensuring smooth navigation across both desktop and mobile devices.

As an added safety measure, STEP Solo prompts users to restart the protocol from the 4 Elements exercise each time they log in before moving on to the processing of distressing memories. This is intended to help clients regulate their emotional state before engaging in self-guided processing. The 4 Elements exercise is always accessible for self-regulation, providing clients with ongoing support throughout their journey.

Providing the STEP Together Intervention



The process for STEP Together groups is as follows:

1. Informed Consent and Information Letter: Review informed consent and terms of use with your client once you determine they may benefit from this protocol.

-  See page 25 for a sample consent

-  See page 26 for a sample information letter

2. Screening and Evaluation: Ask your clients to complete the screening measures to determine if STEP Together is the right fit for their needs.

-  [Initial Screening](#)

3. Screening Review: After receiving all completed screening documents from the client, review the information to determine if STEP Together is an appropriate intervention for them.

- See page 13-22 in the manual for screening information.

4. Decision and Communication: Once you have determined that STEP Together is suitable, notify the STEP Intervention Participant of your decision.

-  See Kajabi for the STEP Together Sample Email document (email ***TOGETHER-3: Scheduling the Group***).

5. Schedule the Group: See details below on page 43.

6. Collect Pre-Group Data: Send the pre-and-post-test data form to monitor participant change before and after the intervention.

-  [Pre-and-Post-Test Data](#)

7. Conduct Meeting One: See STEP Together Script for Group Leaders.

-  The STEP Together Script is available on Kajabi.

8. Meet with STEP Intervention Providers and Participants: Discuss the results of the 4 Elements exercise with the STEP Intervention Providers (Group leaders and Facilitators) to determine if STEP Together is an appropriate intervention for participants. After this discussion, meet with participants individually to discuss the next steps in their care - whether they will complete STEP Together or Supported Steps (one-to-one treatment).

-  See Kajabi for the STEP Together Sample Email document (email ***TOGETHER-6: Processing Meeting*** or ***STEP-3: Discussing Intervention Options***).

9. Conduct Meeting Two: See STEP Together Script for Group Leaders.

-  The STEP Together Script is available on Kajabi.

10. Collect Feedback: See details and link below. See page 47.

- The  Feedback Form is sent in  email ***TOGETHER-6: Processing Meeting*** (See STEP Together Sample Email document on Kajabi).

11. Follow-Up: Check in with your clients to see how the process was for them and discuss the next steps moving forward.

- **Options:** If some group members are interested in further processing, consider offering an additional STEP Together group. For those experiencing an ongoing event, you might provide STEP Solo for continued support or maintain an open STEP Together group that participants can join as needed. The STEP intervention process is designed to be flexible and can be tailored to meet the evolving needs of participants, using your clinical judgement.
-  See Kajabi for the STEP Together Sample Email document (email ***TOGETHER-7: Follow-Up***).

12. Collect Post-Group Data: Send the pre-and-post-test data form to monitor client change before and after the intervention.

-  Pre-and-Post-Test Data
-  See Kajabi for the STEP Together Sample Email document (email ***TOGETHER-8: Post-Group Data***).

 A Participant Checklist Form is available on Kajabi to assist STEP Intervention Providers in tracking the required forms, measures, and materials for each participant.

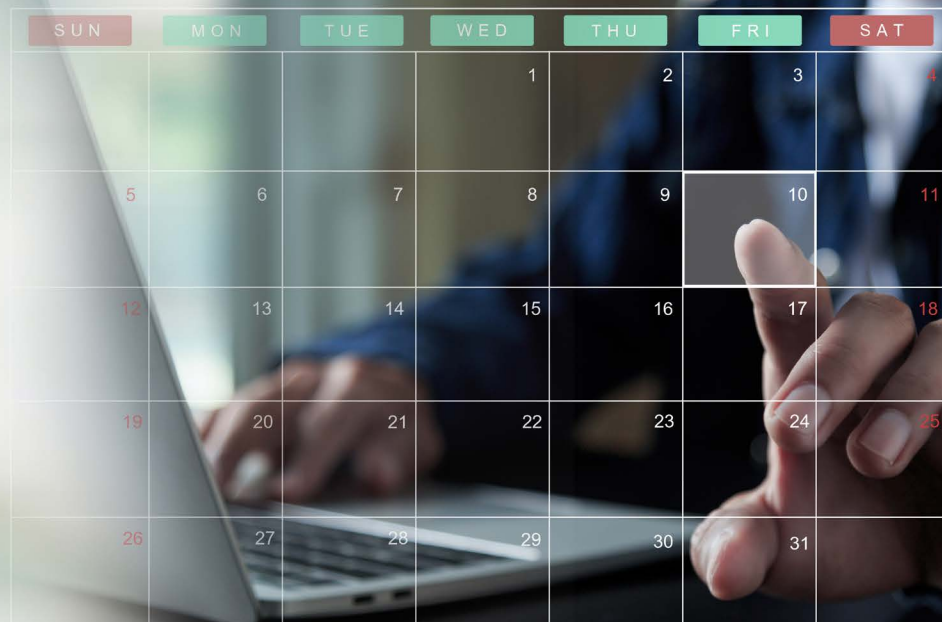
Scheduling the Group

We recommend scheduling the group over two meetings within a short time frame (e.g. 2 meetings over one week) when possible.

- The first meeting will introduce group members, leaders, and facilitators. It will also introduce the STEP Together process and administer further screening through the 4 Elements exercise.
- Between meetings one and two, group leaders and facilitators will meet individually with group members to discuss whether the STEP Together remains appropriate for participants. This will also provide group members the opportunity to discuss how they feel and whether they would like to continue with the group. If necessary, adjustments may be made to the treatment plan to replace STEP Together with Supported Steps (one-to-one treatment).
- The second meeting will include processing the overwhelming experience, self-regulation, and containment.



After you have scheduled a group, let us know by adding it to our [calendar](#).



Tips for Group Leaders and Facilitators

- Choose the Right Platform:
 - Select a secure video conferencing platform to ensure privacy and security (e.g. Zoom Professional, Doxy)
 - This video conferencing platform you choose should be registered to the mental health provider and not an organization to protect participant confidentiality (e.g., some organization Zoom accounts record a transcript of the chat).
- Review Video Conferencing Platform Regularly
 - Familiarize yourself with the platform you have selected to use for the meetings (eg., Zoom, Doxy, etc). Features and layouts change over time.
 - A Technology Cheat Sheet for common video-conferencing platforms is provided on Kajabi. The information reflects updates as of December 2025 and may vary by version or device.
 - Clinicians are encouraged to review their platform settings regularly to stay current to support smooth, safe, and effective meetings.
- Test the platform before your first group to ensure it supports screen sharing and break-out rooms, and to ensure that you are comfortable using these features during the intervention. You might practice these features with the help of a tech support person before running the group with clients.
- Ensure the platform supports mobile devices (e.g., mobile phones or tablets) for those who may not have access to a computer.
- Prioritize Privacy
 - Use a private, password-protected meeting link.
 - Enable the waiting room feature to admit participants manually.
 - Inform participants to attend meetings from a private, quiet location.
 - Ensure you have the address of the location they are joining from.
- Ensure a Strong Internet Connection:
 - Do a trial run to troubleshoot any connectivity issues for providers and facilitators.
 - Use a wired connection or sit close to your Wi-Fi router for stability.
 - Suggest that group members check their internet speed and troubleshoot potential issues beforehand to minimize the possibility they will be disconnected during the group.
- Test Your Equipment
 - Use a good-quality webcam and microphone to ensure clear communication.
 - Wear headphones to reduce background noise and reduce audio feedback.
 - Test your camera angle, lighting, and sound before each meeting.

- Check if a noise suppression setting is enabled on the platform you choose. If noise suppression is on, the music in the background of the 4 Elements video might drop in and out as the setting detects it as background noise.
- Depending on the demographic of your group and their comfort with technology (e.g., for elderly clients):
 - You might choose to offer an initial tech support meeting to familiarize them with the video conferencing platform you will be using, the chat function, and muting/unmuting their microphone.
 - You may need to administer the measures via the phone if they have challenges accessing and completing them on a computer.
 - You may choose to mail a copy of the protocol sheets if they do not have access to a printer and drawing the sheets may be too difficult for the client.
- Prepare for Technology Issues
 - Provide participants with clear instructions for joining the video conferencing platform.
 - Have a backup plan in case participants are disconnected.
 - Send them the 4 Elements audio and graphic.
 - Have a facilitator reach out via phone to help them reconnect to the group.
- Provide participants with clear instructions for what they should do if they are disconnected from the group.
- Set Clear Expectations
 - Share guidelines on video call etiquette, such as muting when not speaking.
 - Clarify rules about confidentiality in an online setting.
- Monitor Participants
 - Remind participants that their cameras must remain on for the entirety of the meeting, and if they have to leave their computer for any reason during the meeting, tell them who to contact.
 - For example, if the participant needs to use the washroom, they should reach out to a facilitator so the facilitator does not call them on their phone to check-in.
 - Monitor body language and tone closely to address disengagement or emotional distress.
- Communicate with group leaders and facilitators
 - Have a private, secure chat with the group leaders and facilitators to discuss any issues that arise during the meeting. This chat will be used to notify your co-facilitators that you are reaching out to a participant or have noticed a participant has disconnected. This chat is for group leaders and facilitators only. It should be held in a separate platform (e.g., a group chat, not the chat box of the video conferencing platform to protect participant privacy).
 - Note and share any accommodation participants may require.

The STEP Together Script for Group Leaders

The STEP Together Script for Group Leaders is available for download on the Kajabi Learning platform (Module: STEP Together Protocol) and serves as a valuable resource for group leaders. It includes a script with suggested wording to guide meetings, helpful tips to keep in mind while facilitating the protocol, and an overview of what to expect in the next steps. This tool is designed to support a smooth and effective group experience.

Meeting One: The Introduction Group

Meeting One provides an opportunity for group leaders, facilitators, and members to connect and familiarize themselves with one another. It also serves as a time to address any technical issues, watch an introductory video outlining the process, and gain an understanding of Bilateral Stimulation (BLS), and the STEP Together protocol. Additionally, participants will view the 4 Elements video as an extra layer of screening for group suitability. Following this meeting, group leaders and facilitators will meet with members to discuss the next steps, whether that involves continuing with the STEP Together intervention or Supported Steps (exploring alternative interventions that may better align with individual needs).

Meeting Two: The Intervention Group

In Meeting Two, participants will review the 4 Elements activity and watch protocol videos designed for individual processing of their overwhelming incident or series of incidences within the group setting. There will also be dedicated time for group discussion, allowing members to explore their strengths, resources, and key takeaways from the meeting. Additionally, participants will watch a video on containment and be reminded to share their feedback forms with group leaders. After the meeting, post-group data collection will take place to help assess the experience and outcomes.

Please note: depending on your group's demographics—such as age, background, or comfort with technology—you may need to plan for additional tech support. You can accommodate this by adding extra time to the beginning of Meeting One or by scheduling a brief, stand-alone technology-troubleshooting meeting before the introductory meeting.

After the STEP Together Group

After the group, please remember to:

1. **Collect Post-Intervention Forms:** Those eligible for the STEP Together group will complete the Pre-and-Post-Data forms using the link below. These measures will need to be completed by the group participants *before* the first meeting (the introduction group) and again one week *after* the second meeting (the intervention group). Please send the link via email to each group member one week after the second meeting (the intervention group) and ensure they are completed. This information can be used to assist in treatment planning.

-  [Pre-and-Post-Test Data](#)

2. **Collect the Feedback Form:** Send participants the link to complete the feedback form. There are two components to the feedback form. The first is a record of their SUDs throughout the protocol sheet for your records and to inform follow-up discussions with your clients. The second portion of the feedback form is anonymous and allows participants to provide feedback to help us develop and improve the protocol. Participants will be asked to complete the feedback form at the end of the group.

- The  [Feedback Form](#) is sent in email  **TOGETHER-6: Processing Meeting** (See STEP Together Sample Email document on Kajabi).

3. **Participant Checklist Form:** Finish the Participant Checklist Form for each group member.

-  See module “Before the Group” on Kajabi.

4. **Follow-up:** Check in with your clients to see how the process was for them and discuss the next steps moving forward.

-  See Kajabi for the STEP Together Sample Email document (email **TOGETHER-7: Follow-Up**).

Emails for STEP Together

List of Emails

- TOGETHER-1: Invite to Participate (with Consent and Information)
- TOGETHER-2: Screening Measures
- TOGETHER-3: Scheduling the Group
- TOGETHER-4: Pre-Intervention Measures
- TOGETHER-5: Introductory Meeting (with Protocol Sheets + 4 Elements + Link)



After the introductory meeting, you will review the results of the 4 Elements exercise, meet with the STEP Intervention Providers, and determine whether STEP Together, Supported Steps, or an alternative intervention may be most appropriate for the participant. Then, schedule a meeting with the participant to discuss the next steps.

- TOGETHER-6: Processing Meeting (with Protocol Sheets + 4 Elements + Link + Feedback Form)
- TOGETHER-7: Follow-Up
- TOGETHER-8: Post-Group Data



Downloadable samples of these emails are available on Kajabi.



STEP Together Platform

STEP Together is hosted on Kajabi, offering users a seamless and intuitive navigation experience. Upon logging in, clinician users are taken directly to their dashboard. After completing the clinician agreement form, they gain full access to the STEP Together intervention. The platform is organized into clear modules, enabling effortless access to videos, written content, and downloadable resources for client support. Additional downloads are strategically placed throughout to help clinicians minimize preparation time. With a responsive interface, users can navigate smoothly across both desktop and mobile devices for a consistently efficient experience.

As clinician users progress through STEP Together, they can mark modules as complete and track their progress with visual indicators. Kajabi's intuitive navigation tools enable seamless movement between modules and allow users to jump directly to specific sections via the table of contents. With convenient access to downloadable materials and a user-friendly design, Kajabi ensures clinicians can efficiently navigate and engage with the STEP Together intervention, making their workflow smooth and hassle-free.

Reminder: The login information and password for STEP Together are for clinicians only and must *not* be shared with clients. Clinicians should share the videos by screen-sharing during meetings—downloading or distributing the videos is not permitted and violates the terms of use. Thank you for your cooperation in maintaining the integrity of the platform.

Self Care Traumatic Episode Protocol (STEP) Together

Resume Course

STEP Together Clinician Agreement



Agreement

Self-Care Traumatic Episode Protocol (STEP) Agreement For STEP Intervention Providers



Providing Supported Steps

Based on the results of the screening measures, the 4 Elements exercise, or your clinical judgement, you may choose to direct a client toward Supported Steps instead of STEP Solo or STEP Together.

If the scores indicate it may not be the best time to continue with the STEP intervention, the clinician uses “Supported Steps” to guide next steps through clinical judgement and any additional assessment. These Supportive Steps are not part of the STEP intervention itself but simply a reminder of a decision point where the clinician will choose the approach that may best meet the client’s needs.

Supported Steps are recommended for:

- Clients with complex trauma.
- Clients who require additional support to engage safely and effectively with STEP interventions.
- Clients whose screening or assessment results indicate difficulty participating in group or autonomous interventions.

Documentation Recommendations

To ensure continuity of care and support clinical decision-making:

- Record interventions used, modifications made, and client responses.
- Note progress in self-regulation skills, treatment goals, or readiness for STEP Solo or STEP Together (when appropriate).
- Document any ongoing concerns or recommendations for continued individual therapy.

Next Steps

After the client has engaged in Supported Steps, use your clinical judgement to determine whether the client may benefit from:

- Joining a STEP Together group for further processing.
- Using STEP Solo as a maintenance tool to reinforce skills and progress.
- Continuing with individual therapy using an appropriate modality.

When determining the next steps for a client, assess their readiness by evaluating emotional regulation, skill acquisition, safety, and overall engagement with the intervention. Consider whether participation in a group setting or independent practice would best support continued growth, and take into account ongoing clinical needs as well as trauma-related considerations to guide your decision on the most appropriate subsequent intervention.

Next Steps

If you feel confident in your understanding, you may review the online materials and proceed with the next steps in the protocol. If you need further clarification, you can revisit the manual, online materials, or seek additional support as needed.



In addition, monthly consultation groups are available to provide ongoing guidance and support. These sessions offer EMDR clinicians a space to discuss cases, delve into advanced applications of EMDR Therapy, and ask questions about the STEP Intervention and other EMDR protocols.

Ongoing consultation is a valuable resource for enhancing clinical skills, staying current with best practices, and fostering a supportive professional community.



“ Every step forward in processing
opens space for the client’s
natural resilience to emerge. ”

Quote inspired by the writing of Dr. Francine Shapiro

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